

UR: ARG and the Magic Circle

By

Jorge Salazar, Samuel Stacey, Jozu Sepahi

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Introduction

How far can puzzle logic be extended outside the game window before the magic circle breaks?

Huizinga's **Magic Circle**

“Inside the play-ground an absolute and peculiar order reigns...Play demands order absolute and supreme. ”

Huizinga, *Homo Ludens*, 16.

**“The player who trespasses against the rules or ignores them is a
"spoil-sport".”**

Huizinga, *Homo Ludens*, 11.

Juul – Half-Real / Rules and Fiction

**“Rules separate the game from the rest
of the world by carving out an area where the rules
apply; fiction projects
a world different from the real world.”**

Jesper Juul, *Half-Real*, 164

Agon & Ilinx

-ARG (Alternate Reality Game)
-Transmedia

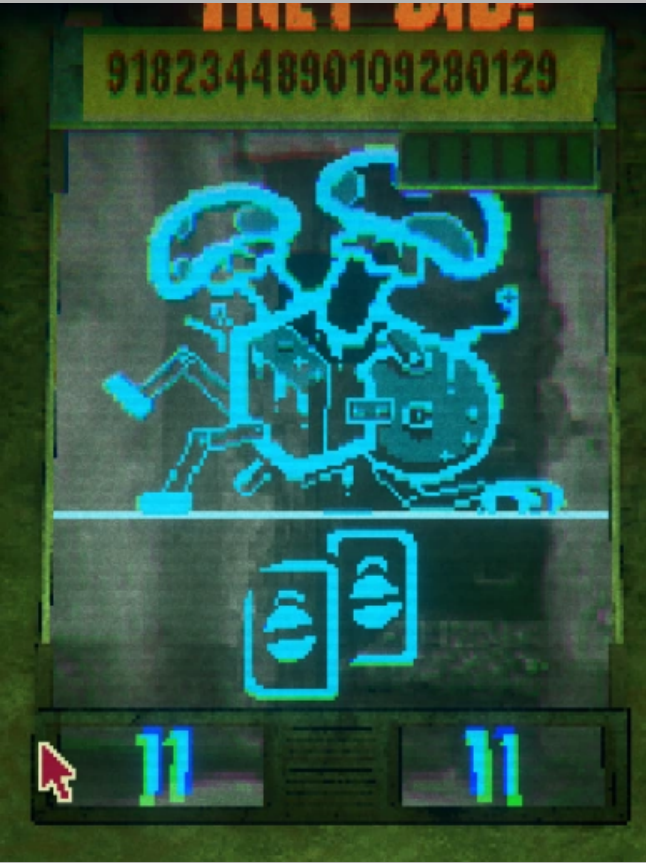
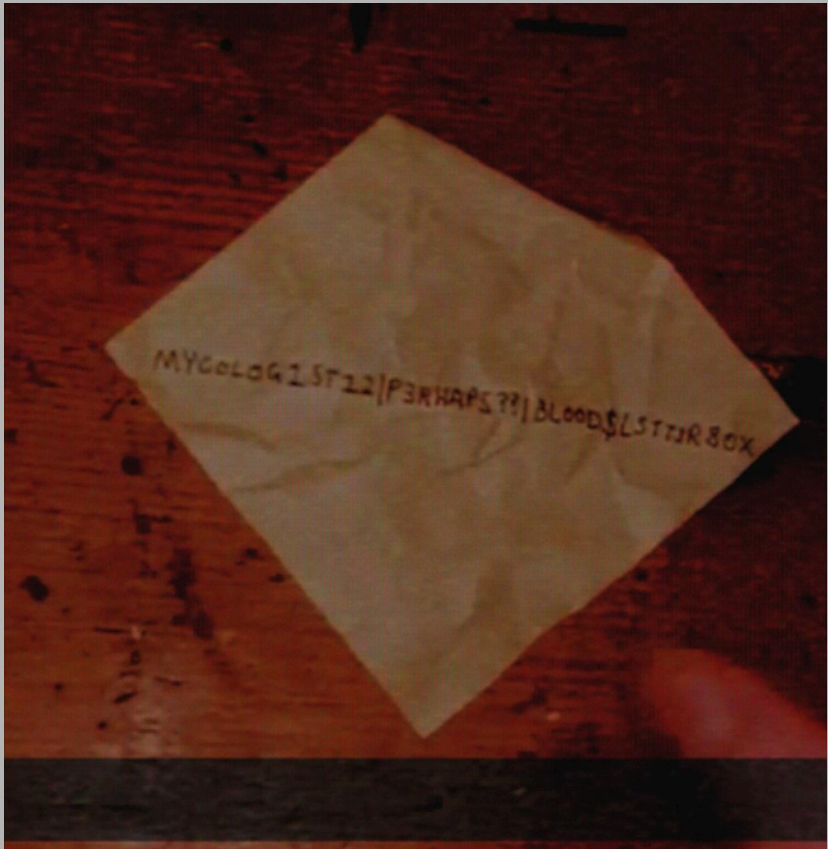
Overwatch



Entertainment, B. (2014). Overwatch.



Inscryption



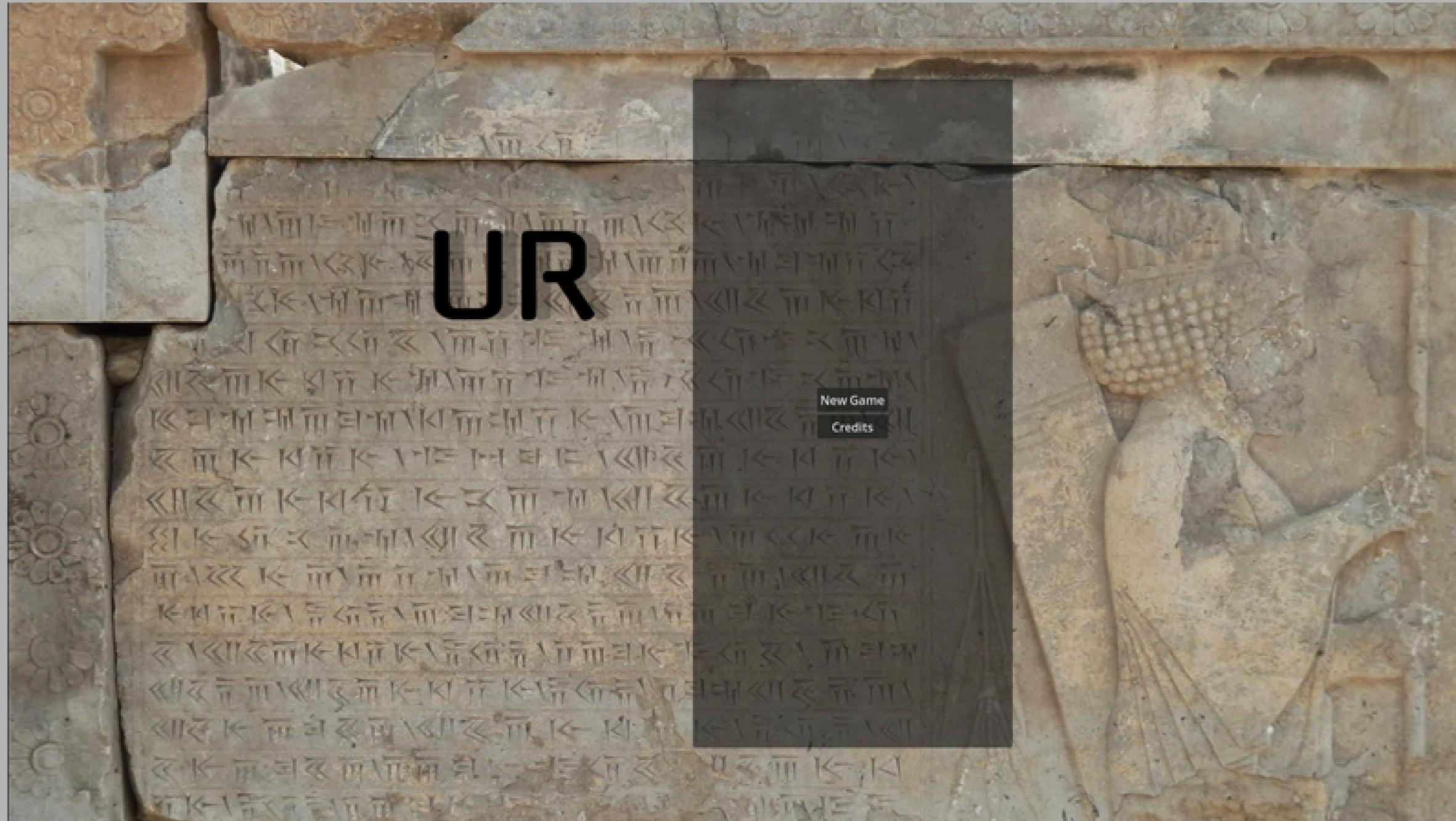
Games, D. M. (2021). Inscyption.

“...a process where integral elements of a fiction get dispersed systematically across multiple delivery channels for the purpose of creating a unified and coordinated entertainment experience.”

Henry Jenkins, *Transmedia Storytelling 101*.

Case Study: Our Prototype

5 in game tutorial puzzles, 4 transmedia puzzles
Made with Godot 4.5, web, image and video
Follows a simple sign-based puzzle language



TESTING INSTRUCTIONS:

The game should take ~45 minutes to complete.

The game is over when you see the following image:



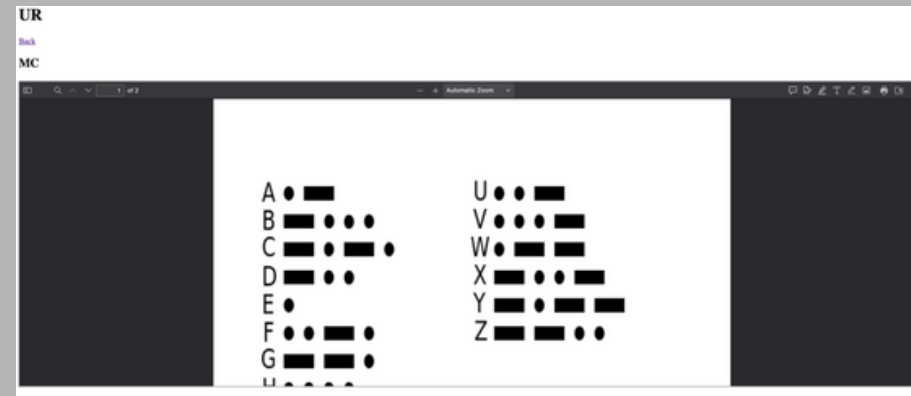
If you're stuck you can ask one of us for a hint (can just message). You don't need to struggle for more than ~3 minutes before asking for a hint, it's totally fine.

Before the play session, show them this image:

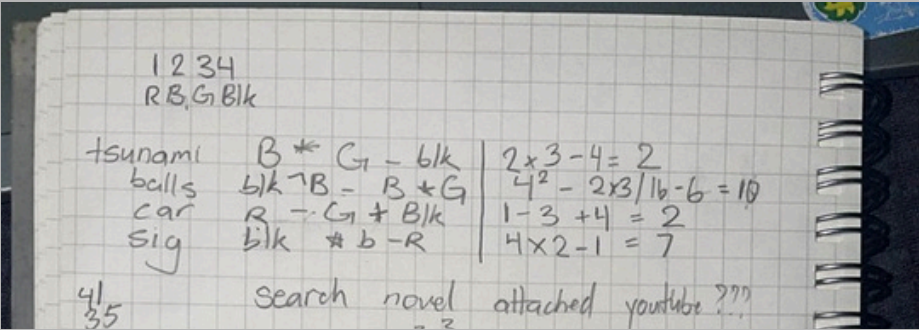
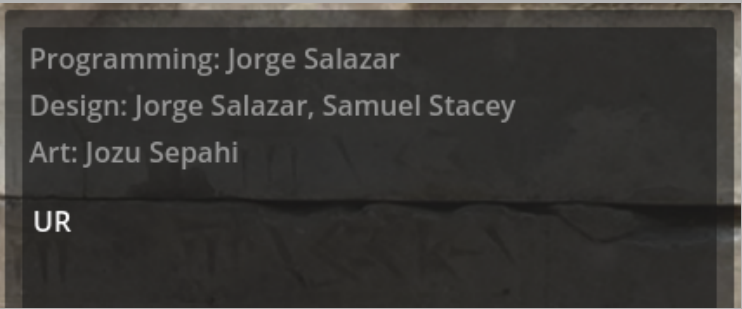


When you see this image, the game is over.

We will bring paper and pens.



<https://puzmzeethis.neocities.org/>



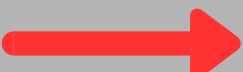
Game Window



Browser



Game Window



Game Files

check the game files



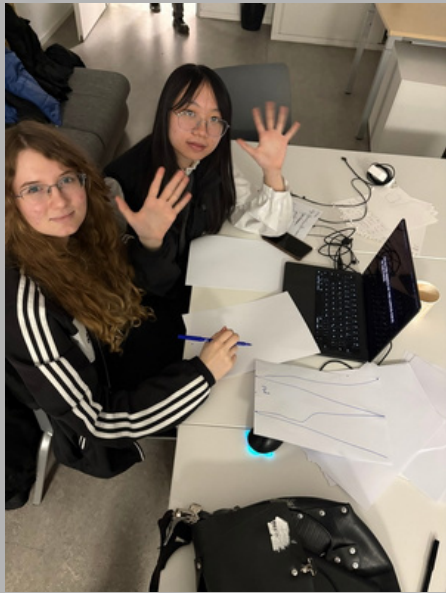
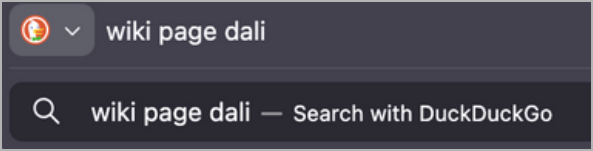
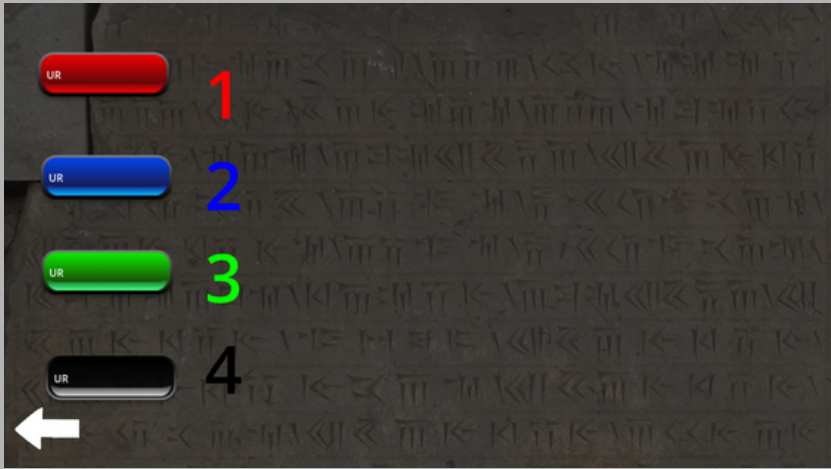
Browser

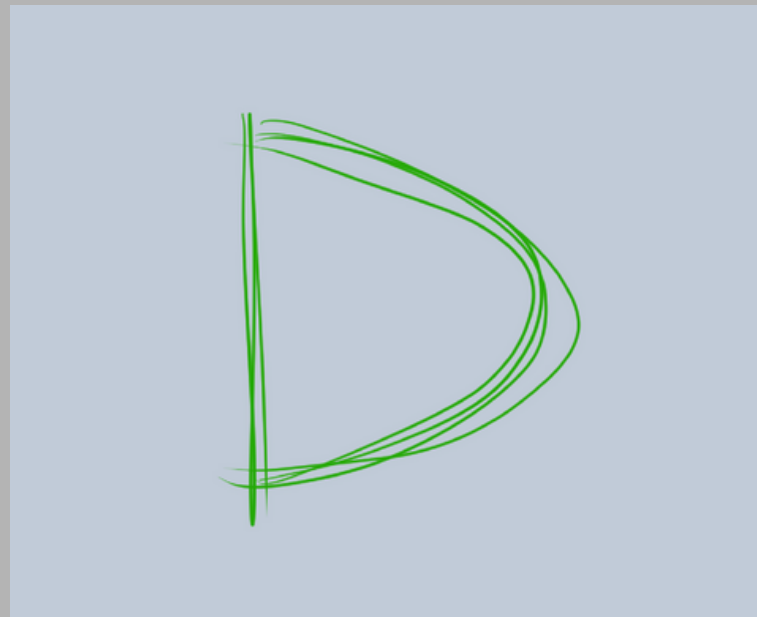
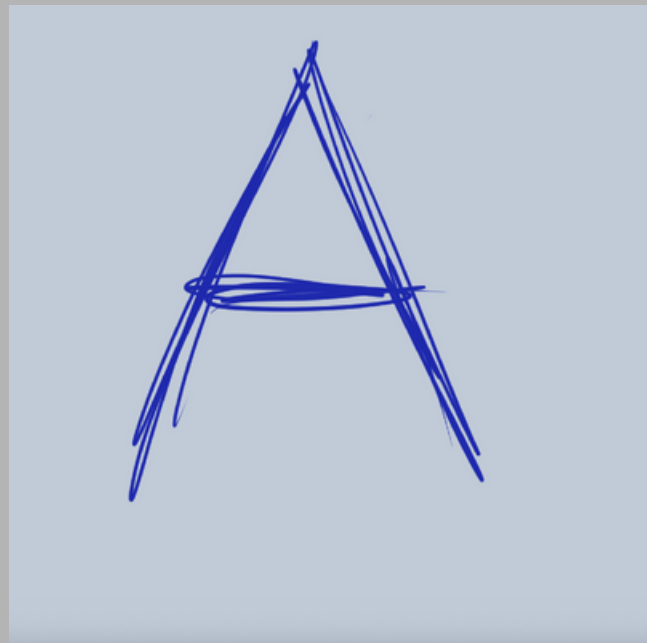
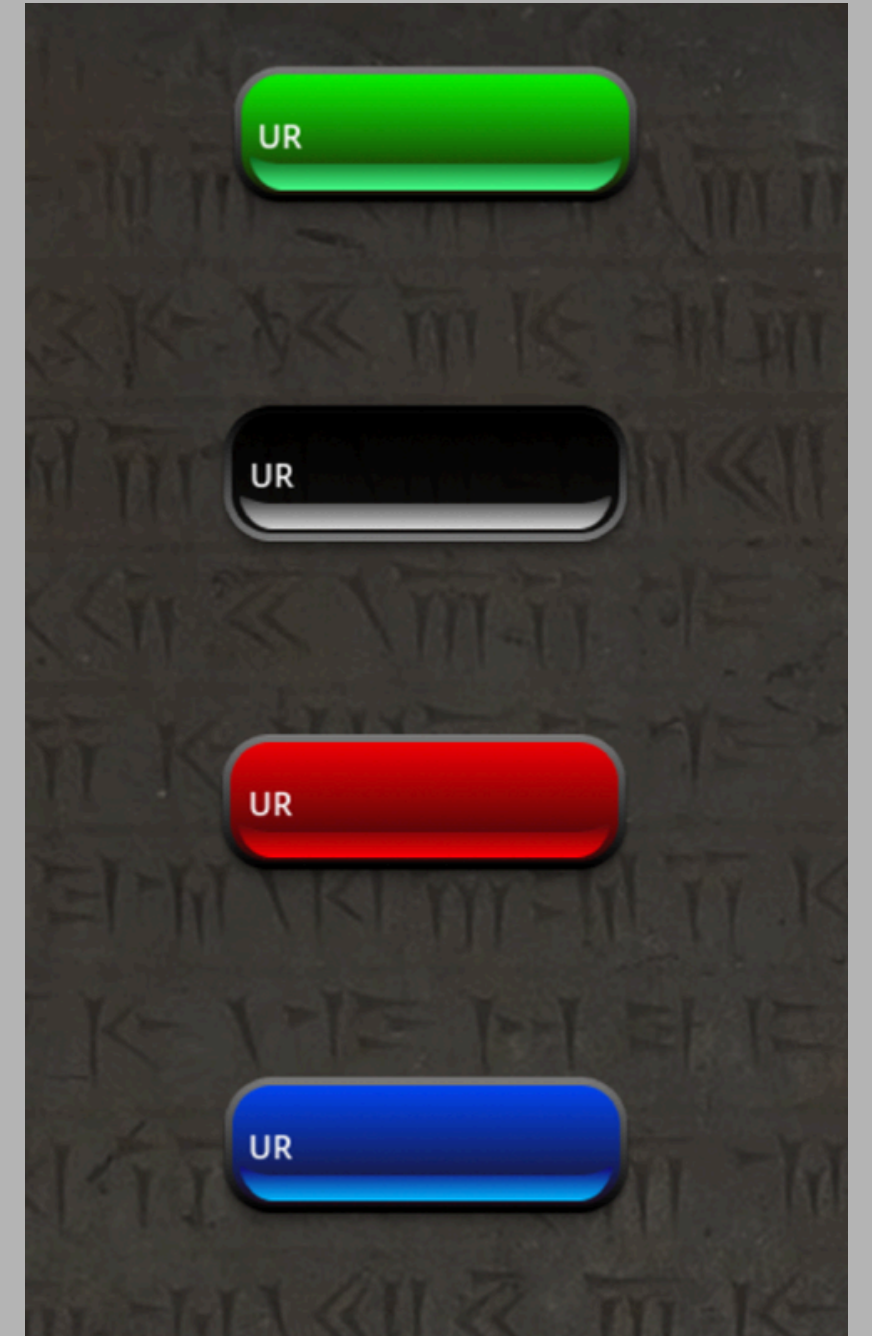
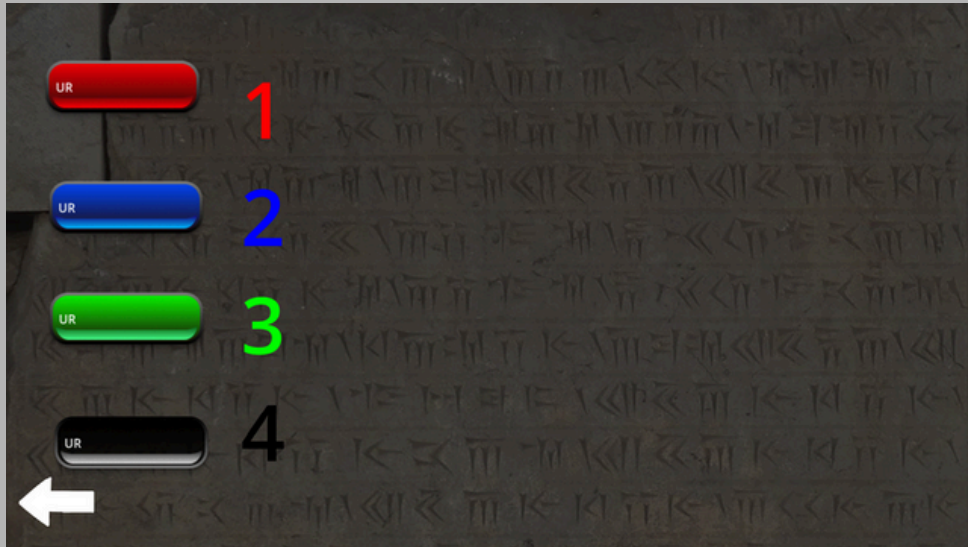


Tabletop

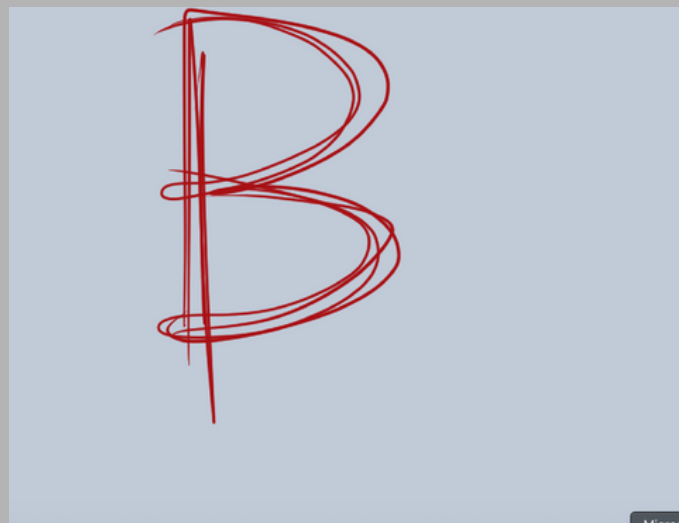


Browser





**“Supreme
Order”**



“Spoil-Sport”

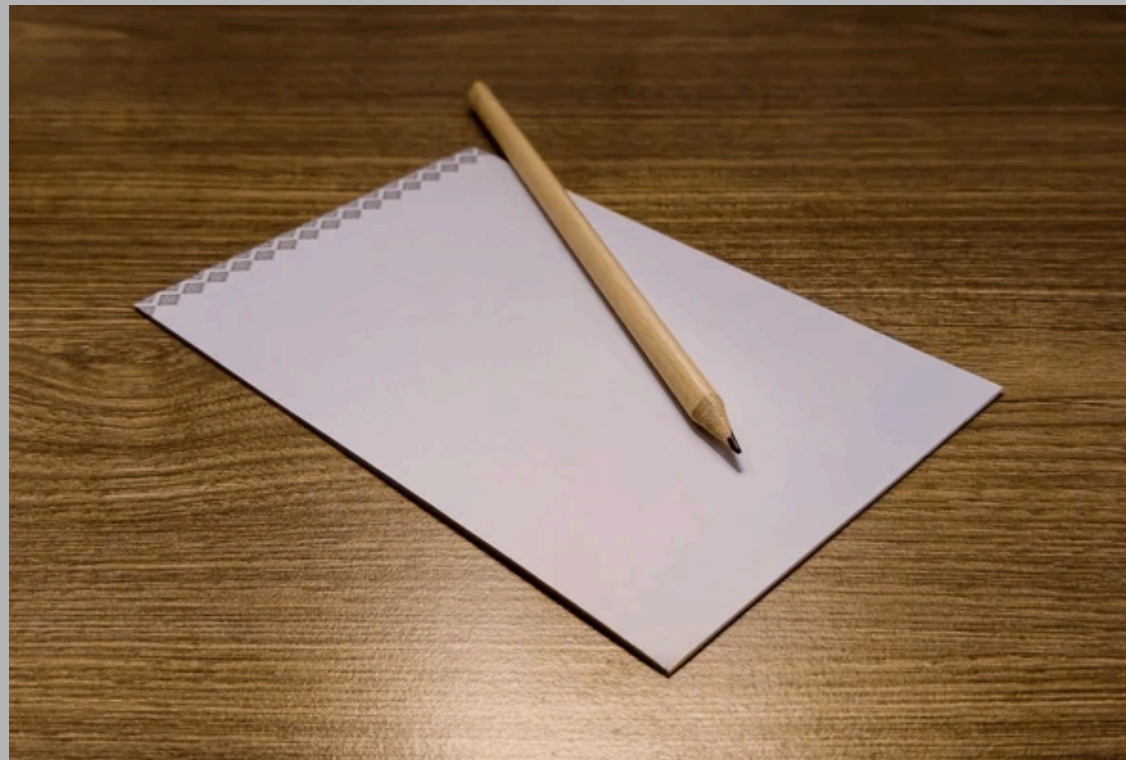
|1234
RBGb

tsunami = B * G - b

eyeballs = b^B - B * G

carrier = R - G + b

signature = b * B - R

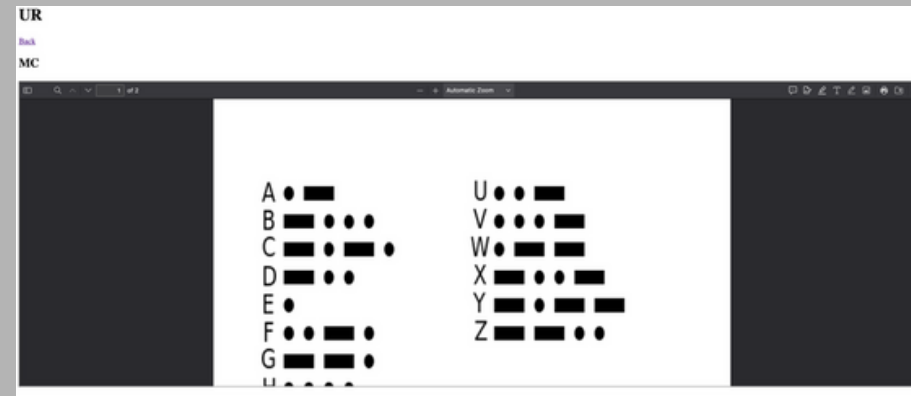


Color + Number =

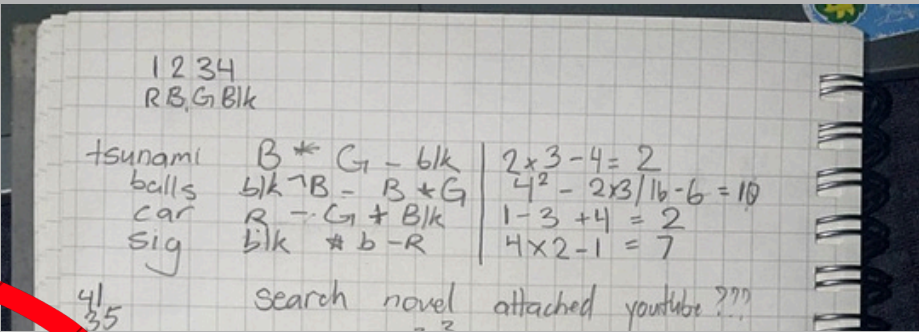
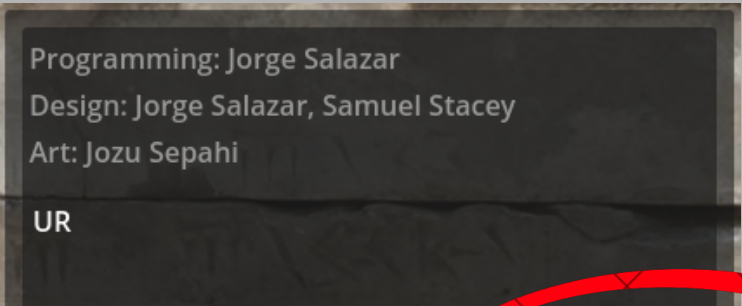
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<https://puzmlzeethis.neocities.org/>

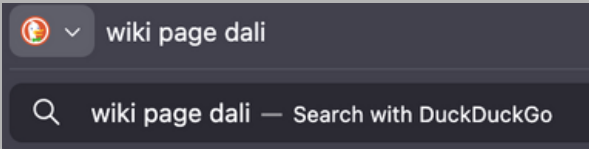
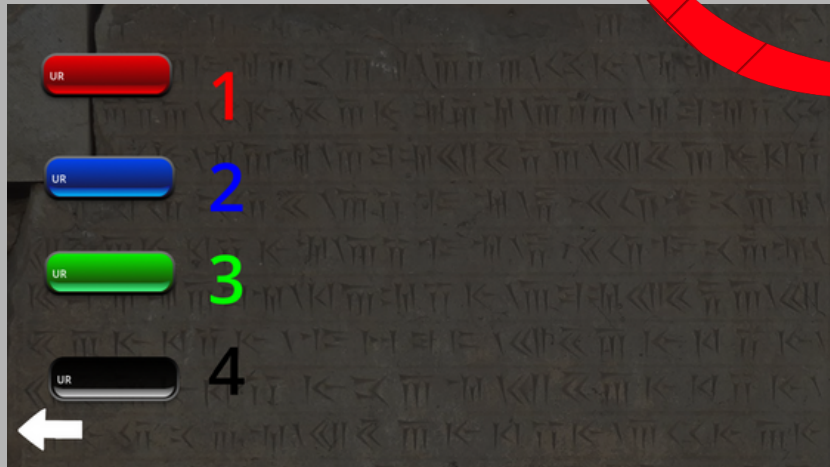


Game Window

Browser

Game Window

Game Files



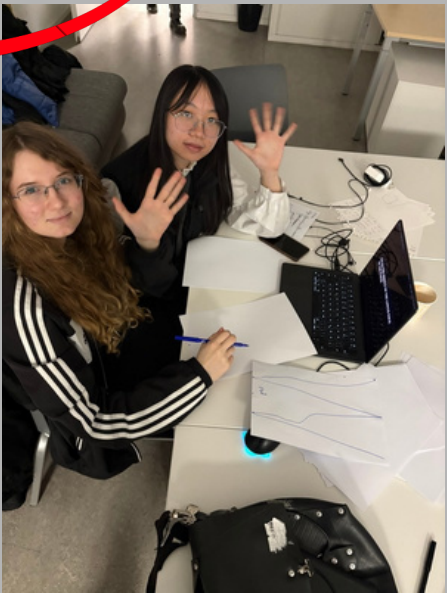
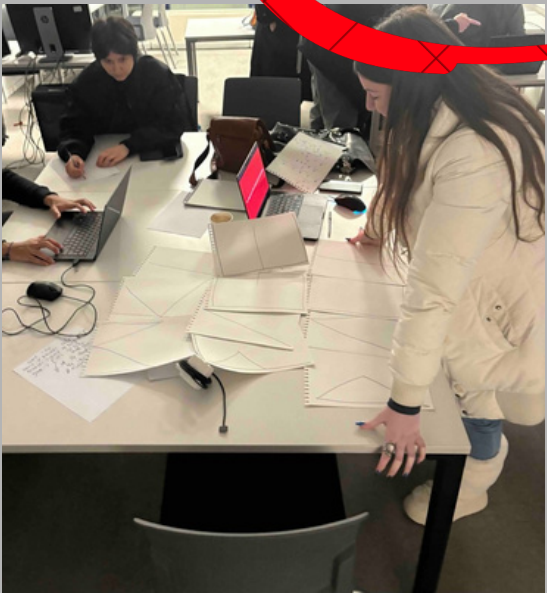
Browser

Tabletop

Browser



Dalí in the 1960s, sporting his "very aggressive" mustache,^[230] holding his pet ocelot, Babou



Time to beat, use of hints

Short survey after gameplay

Tijana*	
Kelly & Lidia*	
Fritz*	
Tom	
Damien/Mahito**	
Klara	
Weston	
Andrea	
Jakub	
Cait	
Jupiter**	

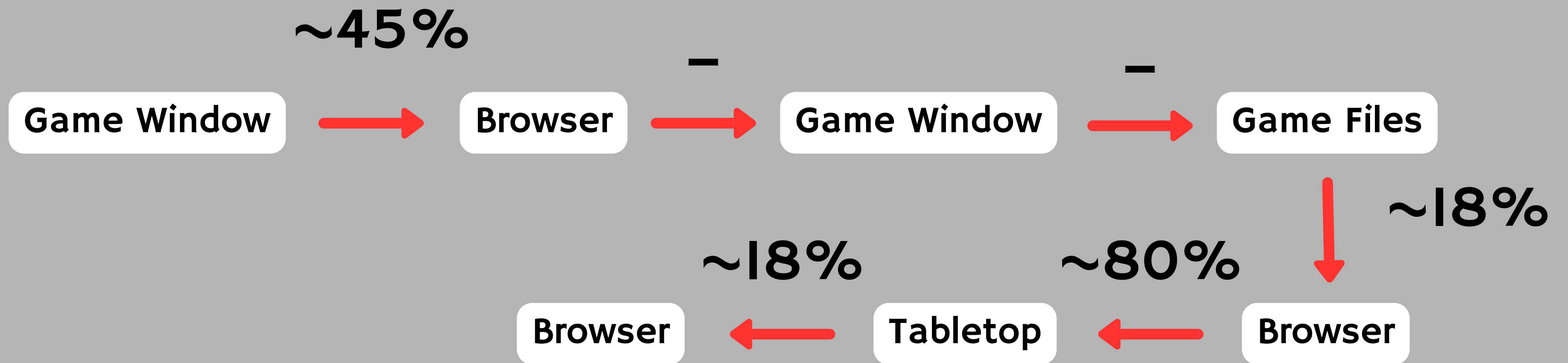
11 play sessions, 12 players, 2 online

37.89 minutes

2.09 hints

Puzzle system was clear: 70%

ARG* familiarity: 70%



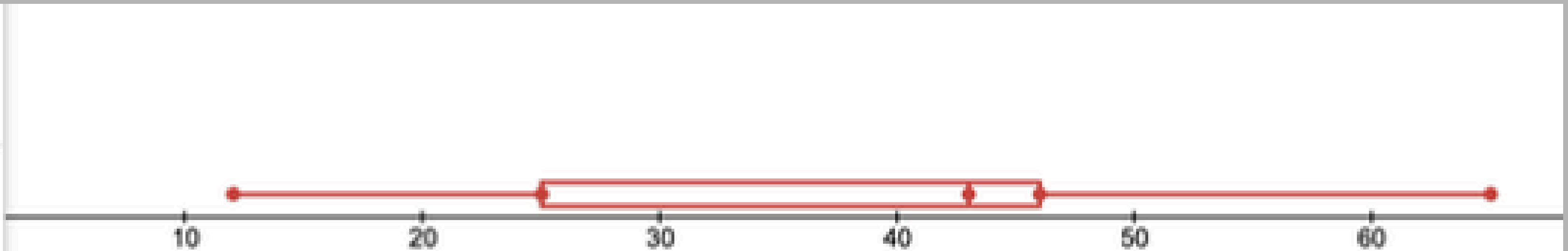
Q0 = 12

Q1 = 25

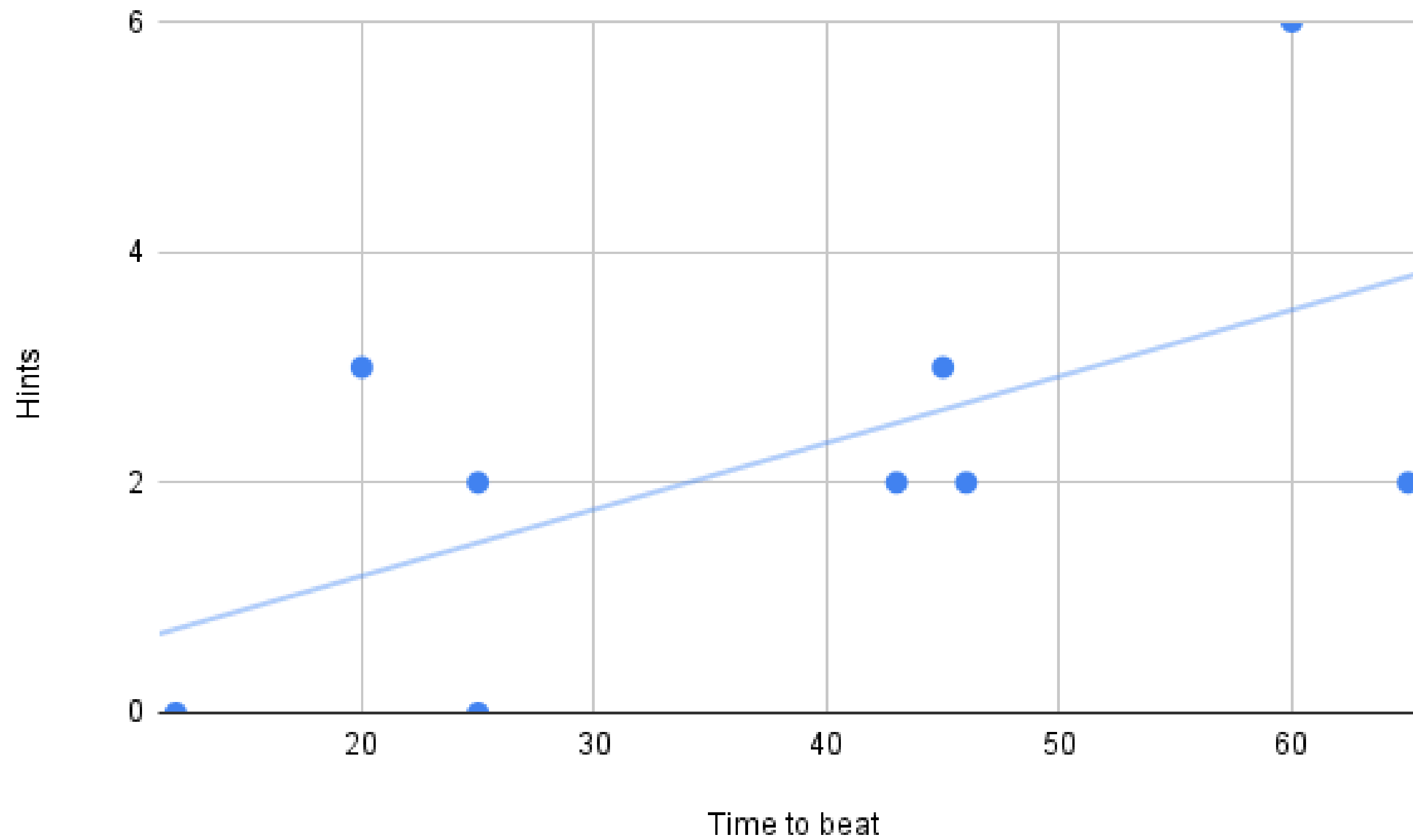
Q2 = 43

Q3 = 46

Q4 = 65



Made using Desmos (<https://www.desmos.com/calculator/h9icuu58wn>)



Hints:hint on 1	0.4950737715
Time:clear	-0.4484927217
Hints:clear	-0.3351775152

Meta-Horror Games



4 people
mentioned
DDLC

Salvato, D. (2017). Doki Doki Literature Club.

OFF

2 people
mentioned
OFF



Unproductive Fun Time (2008). OFF.

At what point did you realise you had to leave the game window?

When clicking the link and nothing else was working and Sam said sarcastically, "Yeah its a link"

When you told me lol.

I stared at a URL for a little while until I realised I had to type it in a browser.

It took me a minute to figure out that the link was supposed to be put in the browser since I wasn't expecting the game to go outside the application itself.

Which clues felt like part of the game, which felt ‘outside’?

I think all of them at least felt like

the colors felt like part of the game and so did the video and the math. the images in the files and the morse code felt like outside influence

It all felt outside of whatever the fuck game I was playing.

The colours definitely felt like a part of the game, especially since it was always a constant, but the browser, game files and the video definitely felt "outside"

$\begin{matrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 \\ R & B & G & Blk \end{matrix}$
 $\begin{matrix} 51b & a & d & c \\ 32F & x & o & A \end{matrix}$

$\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot & \cdot & \cdot\cdot \\ R & E & D \end{matrix}$
 $\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot\cdot \\ 6 \end{matrix}$

$\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot\cdot & \cdot\cdot & \cdot & \cdot\cdot & \cdot\cdot \\ B & L & A & C & K \end{matrix}$
 $\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot\cdot\cdot \\ 3 \end{matrix}$

$\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot & \cdot & \cdot & \cdot & \cdot \\ G & R & E & E & N \end{matrix}$
 $\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot\cdot\cdot \\ 4 \end{matrix}$

$\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot\cdot & \cdot\cdot & \cdot & \cdot\cdot & \cdot\cdot \\ B & L & U & E & 9 \end{matrix}$
 $\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot & \cdot & \cdot\cdot & \cdot\cdot\cdot & \cdot\cdot\cdot\cdot \\ B & A & C & K & T & O & C & R & E & D \end{matrix}$
 $\begin{matrix} \cdot\cdot\cdot \\ S \end{matrix}$

Cait
 RED 6
 BLACK 3
 GREEN 4
 BLUE 9

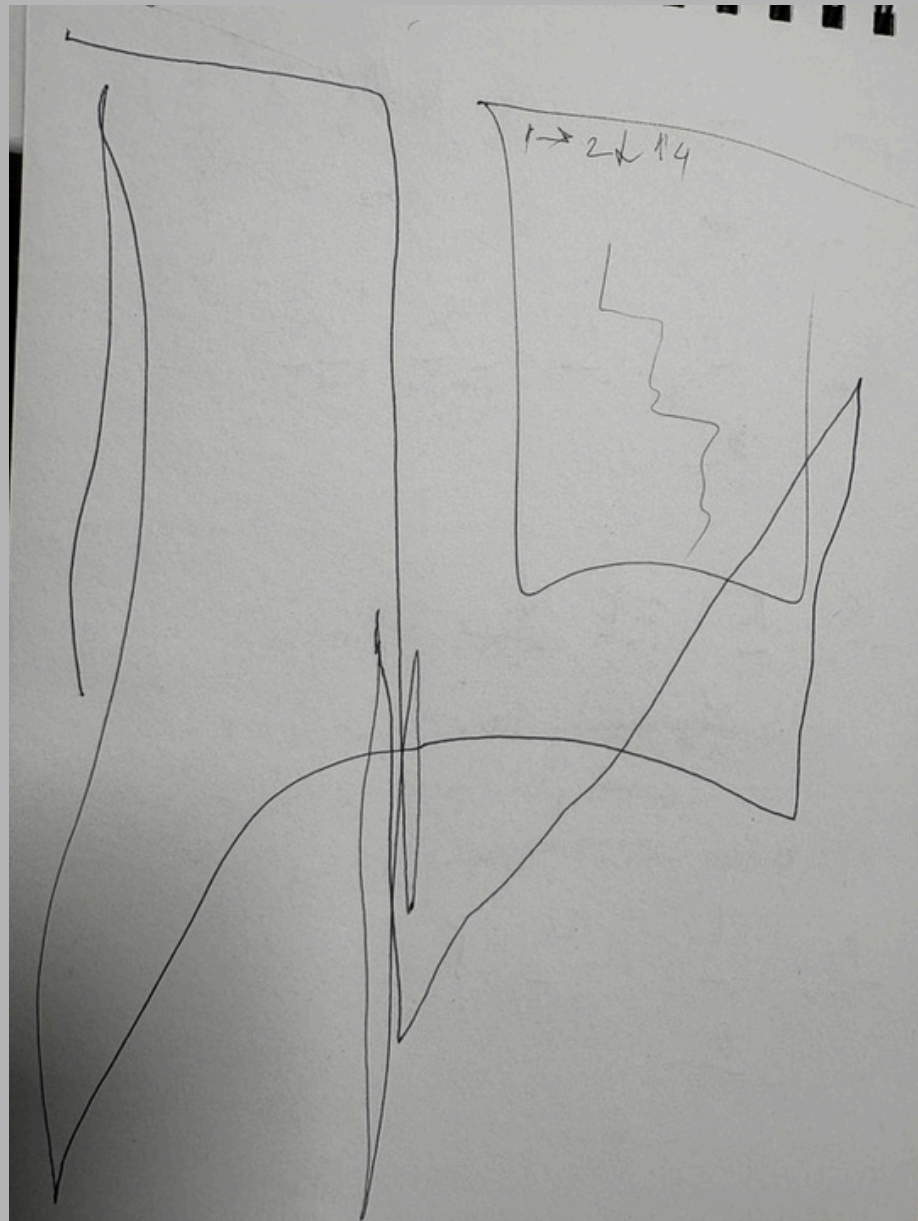
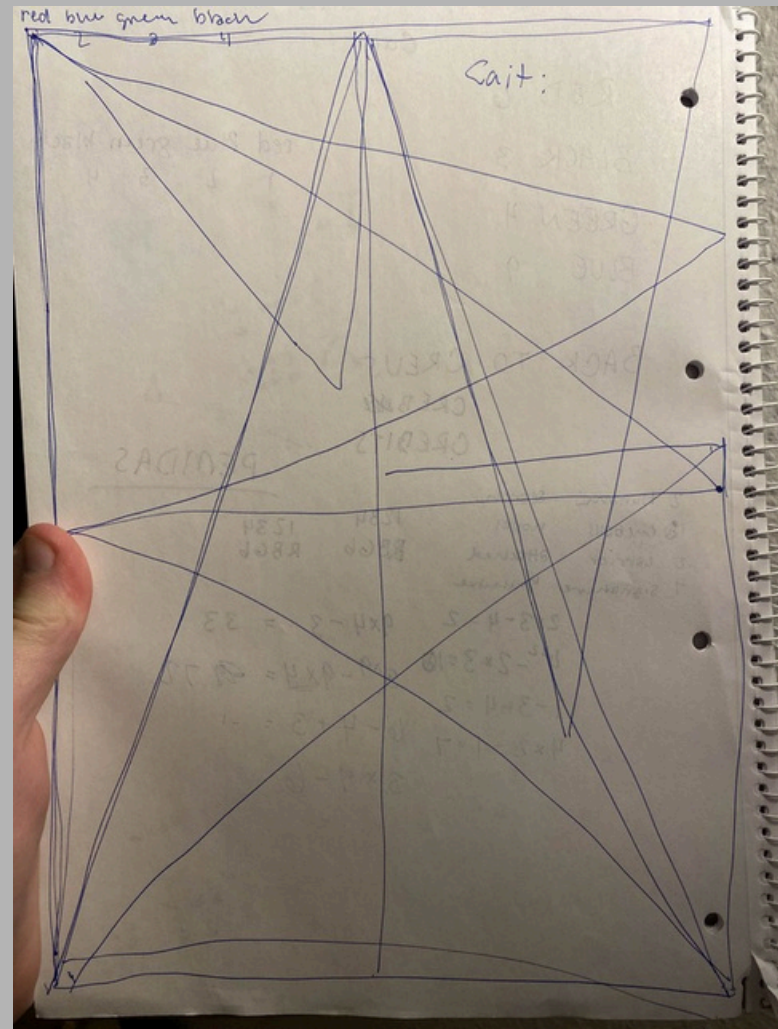
BACK TO CREUS
 CREB
 CREDITS

PEMDAS

2 tsunami search 1234 1234
 1 eyeballs novel BBGbb RBGbb
 2 carrier attached
 1 signature youtube

$2 \times 3 - 4 = 2$
 $4^2 - 2 \times 3 = 10$
 $1 - 3 + 4 = 2$
 $4 \times 2 - 1 = 7$

$9 \times 4 - 3 = 33$
 $3^9 - 9 \times 4 = 72$
 $6 - 4 + 3 = -1$
 $3 \times 9 - 6$



red blue green black
 WAKI WIKI
 PAGE PAGE
 DALI

red blue green black
 WAKI WIKI
 PAGE PAGE
 DALI

2 hints
 Coodiff
 Youtube
 Order

12 mins

Fri+2:

red blue green black
 WAKI WIKI
 PAGE PAGE
 DALI

Takeaways from data

Challenges & Limitations

Conclusion

Our findings suggest that the magic circle is defined by semiotic coherence rather than the physical location of signs.

Suggested Research

Bibliography

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7. UR. Samuel Stacey, Jorge Salazar, Jozu Sepahi, 2025. PC game.
8. The Witness. Directed by Johnathan Blow, Thekla, Inc. 2016. PC game.
9. Doki Doki Literature Club. Dan Salvato. 2017. PC game.
10. OFF. Directed by Mortis Ghost, Unproductive Fun Time. 2008. PC game.

Questions?